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• Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001; Phones: 23315801-4;
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Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Park, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton
House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai,
2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 04; Phones: 2847626-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In; Fax: 28472178; Cable:
Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones:
22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 6-3, 85/7B,
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• 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C-3, Road, Ahmedabad-380006;
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When we sat down to pick our newsmaker, it was pretty clear to us that no matter who the other contenders—businessmen, athletes, entertainers, other politicians—there was really one person who would make the cut. Our newsmakers have always been people who come to dominate both the national debate and the nightly headlines, be it Osama bin Laden in 2001 or Sonia Gandhi in 2004.

In 2007, only one person qualified. The dominant political theme this year was the Left's combined resistance to a new wave of economic reforms proposed by the Government. The most resonant political issue of the year turned out to be the deadlock over the signing of the Indo-US nuclear deal. It very nearly took apart the ruling UPA coalition and brought down the Government with it.

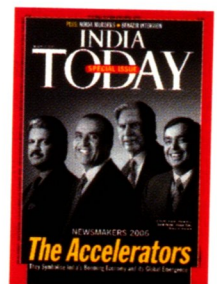
All through 2007, one man came to exemplify the resistance to reform and the nuclear deadlock. CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat, the voice and face of leftist protest, holds no office in government and enjoys no official powers. Yet today he is the second most important politician in the country, after Sonia Gandhi. For a while, he even managed to be the most important. He had to be our Newsmaker for 2007.

This was the year Prime Minister Manmohan Singh tried to define the legacy of his prime ministership by cementing closer ties with the US through the nuclear deal and expanding the ambit of economic liberalisation. At every step, he found himself frustrated by Karat's ideological orthodoxy.

Whatever you may make of Karat's beliefs, more than any other political figure in the country this year, he has been consistent in the stands he has taken and persistent about what he wants. He proved to be a dangerous adversary—an austere, no-nonsense anti-American, anti-'neo-liberal' apparatchik with nothing to lose.

Long saddled with the gerontocracy of Jyoti Basu and Harkishen Singh Surjeet, in Karat the Left has unequivocally found a leader for the future. The tragedy for India is that there is little that is new or forward about the Left's politics even today.

As part of our Newsmaker of the Year cover story, we profile Karat and trace his rise to the centrestage of national politics. Editor Prabhu Chawla and Principal Correspondent Satarupa Bhattacharjya interviewed the comrade in his office. Disapproving of the domination of personality over party, Karat was extremely wary of being featured as the Newsmaker of the Year. He was, shall we say, dogmatic about insisting that he did not want his appearance on the cover of this magazine to look like an endorsement of any kind. Clearly, Karat takes his ideology very seriously. Today India has no choice but to take Prakash Karat seriously too.



Our Newsmakers of '06

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)